

Varicon Aqua – UX Audit Report

Website: www.variconaqua.com

Executive Summary

Varicon Aqua Solutions Ltd is a UK company that makes and sells specialist equipment for growing algae. Their products include photobioreactors (tanks and systems that grow algae in controlled conditions), aquaculture live feed systems, and related supplies. The company started in 2004 and has installed systems in over 400 locations worldwide.

This report reviews the Varicon Aqua website (www.variconaqua.com). It looks at how easy the website is to use, how the pages are organized, and how well it works on mobile phones and tablets.

The core problem is this: **the website acts like an online product catalogue instead of a sales tool**. It lists products but does not clearly explain what problems Varicon can solve for the visitor. This means many potential customers leave the website without making an enquiry.

This report identifies every specific problem found on the website and proposes clear, practical fixes for each one.

Section 1: Terminology Problems Found on the Varicon Website

- ‘Reed Mariculture’ and ‘Inve Artemia’ are shown next to Varicon’s own products in a way that makes them look like Varicon’s own brands. These are third-party partner products that Varicon resells – this must be made clearly and visibly obvious on the website.

Section 2: Audit Findings

What the Website Does Well

- **Clear opening tagline:** The tagline “Concept to Cultivation” at the top of the homepage quickly tells visitors what Varicon does: they help customers go from an initial idea all the way to a working commercial cultivation system. This is a strong and memorable opening.
- **Well-known client names:** The website mentions recognized clients like Cyanotech and Veolia. For a B2B company, naming big clients is one of the fastest ways to build

trust with new visitors. However, these names are placed in the wrong position on the page and need to be shown much more prominently.

Problems Found on the Website

1. The Page Structure Is Disorganized

The homepage jumps randomly between high-level overviews and very specific technical details. There is no clear logical flow. Visitors need to be taken on a logical journey: first understand what Varicon does, then decide if it fits their needs, then contact the company. The current structure breaks that journey completely.

2. Too Much Text, No Structure

The consultancy and engineering services sections are written as large blocks of unbroken text. There are no expandable panels, tabs, or sections that let visitors choose what to read. Most visitors will feel overwhelmed and stop reading long before they reach the important details.

3. Duplicate Sections That Look Identical

There are two separate product carousels (scrolling image galleries) on the homepage. Both look exactly the same. Visitors cannot tell them apart. This forces people to scroll through repetitive sections to find what they need, instead of finding everything clearly in one place.

4. The Navigation Menu Is Overwhelming

The navigation menu has three layers of nested sub-menus and shows more than 15 items at once. This is far too many choices. It overwhelms visitors and makes it very difficult – especially for first-time visitors – to decide where to go next.

5. Empty “Wrapper” Categories in the Menu

The menu items “Information” and “Contact” are just empty labels that contain other links. They serve no purpose on their own. They simply make visitors click an extra time before reaching the actual page they want. These should be removed.

6. No Breadcrumb Navigation on Deeper Pages

On deeper pages (such as specific product pages), there is no breadcrumb trail. A breadcrumb shows visitors where they are, like: Home > Technologies > Photobioreactors. Without this, visitors lose track of where they are and struggle to navigate back to previous sections.

7. The Hero Section Is Vague and Hard to Understand

The large banner at the top of the homepage is filled with technical industry language that most new visitors will not immediately understand. The sections that follow are also not in a logical order – the page does not guide visitors from curiosity through to enquiry in any structured way.

8. Two Product Sections That Look the Same

There are two product carousels on the homepage – one for live feed equipment and one for technology products – but both use the same visual design. Because they look identical, visitors cannot tell which section they are looking at. This causes real confusion.

9. Spelling Error and Overlapping Service Descriptions

There is a spelling mistake in the Services section: the word “Assessments” is written as “Assesments” (one ‘s’ missing). Additionally, Service items 5 and 7 describe what appear to be the same deliverable in slightly different words. This sends mixed messages to potential clients about exactly what Varicon offers.

10. The About Us Page Has Missing Team Details

Team members are listed on the About Us page but without job titles or areas of responsibility. Visitors cannot tell who does what at the company. There is also a factual error: some pages say Varicon has 30 years of experience, while others say 40 years. This inconsistency looks careless and damages trust.

11. No Clear “Next Step” Button Anywhere on the Site

The main navigation bar has no “Get a Quote” or “Contact Us” button anywhere in sight. Visitors who are ready to enquire have no obvious place to go. The buttons in the hero section only link to product category pages rather than encouraging a direct action. The contact form at the bottom of the homepage also has no explanation of response times, who will reply, or any privacy reassurance.

12. No Key Statistics, and Testimonials Are Hidden at the Bottom

The homepage does not show any headline numbers or key facts about the company – such as how many systems have been installed or how many years Varicon has been operating. These facts are one of the quickest ways to convince a potential B2B buyer that Varicon is credible. Worse, the customer testimonials (which are among the most persuasive pieces of content on the site) are placed at the very bottom of the homepage, where most visitors will never scroll far enough to see them.

13. Navigation Breaks on Mobile Phones

The complex multi-level navigation menu will not work properly on mobile phones and tablets. The menu items are too small to tap, and there is not enough screen space to display three levels of drop downs. Additionally, the website uses placeholder graphics while images load. On a slow internet connection, these placeholders stay on screen for a long time, making the website look broken or unfinished.

Recommended Fixes

Fix 1: Simplify the Navigation Menu

Remove the empty “wrapper” categories. Reduce drop downs to a maximum of one or two levels. Reorganize the menu around what visitors actually need: Products, Services, Case Studies, About Us, and a clearly visible “Get a Quote” button.

Fix 2: Reorder the Homepage Sections

Reorder the homepage so it takes visitors through a logical journey: first show that Varicon is relevant to them, then build confidence, then present the solution, then show real-world proof, and finally guide them to take action. Move industry information and testimonials much higher up the page. Merge the duplicate product carousels into one clear section.

Fix 3: Rewrite the Hero Section

Rewrite the homepage banner so it clearly and directly answers three questions: What does Varicon Aqua do? Who is it for? What should I do next? Replace the category-link buttons with action-focused buttons designed to convert visitors into enquirers – for example: “Start Your Project” or “Speak to a Specialist”. Add small clickable industry tags (e.g., [Aquaculture], [Biotech], [Agriculture]) in the hero section so visitors can instantly filter the experience to their own industry.

Fix 4: Create a Single, Unified Product Section

Replace the multiple identical-looking carousels with one unified product section that uses a tabbed layout. Tabs labeled “Photobioreactors”, “Live Feed Equipment”, and “Consumables” let visitors switch between categories in one place – no more confusion, no more repeated scrolling.

Fix 5: Explain All Technical Terms

Add brief, plain-language descriptions below every product name and technical term. Alternatively, add tool-tip pop-ups that appear when a visitor hovers over a technical word. This makes the website accessible to visitors who are not yet specialists in algae cultivation or aquaculture.

Fix 6: Replace the Services Text Blocks with a Visual Timeline

Replace the long text paragraphs in the Services section with a clear, visual step-by-step timeline. Label each stage of Varicon’s service process: Feasibility Study, Plant Design, Scale-Up, and Commercialization. Visitors can click each stage to expand the detail. This is much faster and easier to follow than dense text blocks.

Fix 7: Show Trust Signals Early on the Page

Move key credibility indicators near the top of the homepage: total systems installed, years in business, client testimonials, and case study highlights. These should be visible before most visitors scroll down. The facts alone will do more to build trust than any amount of written description.

Fix 8: Improve the About Us Page

Add a proper job title and a short professional biography for every team member. Fix the experience year discrepancy (30 years vs. 40 years – it must be one consistent number). Add a visual company history timeline showing key milestones. Clearly list technology partners and third-party brands separately from Varicon’s own products.

Fix 9: Add a Permanent “Get a Quote” Button

Place a “Get a Quote” or “Contact Us” button permanently in the site header, visible on every single page. Improve the contact form by adding: expected response time, who will be responding, and a data privacy assurance statement.

Fix 10: Fix Mobile and Accessibility Issues

Replace the current multi-level drop down menu on mobile with a clean, full-screen overlay menu using expandable accordion sections. Test the entire website on all common screen sizes. Review and update the site to meet WCAG accessibility guidelines so it works for visitors with visual or motor disabilities.

Fix 11: Add Search and Extra Features

Add a search bar so visitors can instantly find what they need. Consider adding a product comparison tool, educational guides or short videos for visitors new to algae cultivation, and dedicated landing pages tailored to each industry Varicon serves (aquaculture, biotech, agriculture, etc.).

Section 3: Proposed Homepage Layout

The problems found in the audit can be fixed by redesigning the homepage around the **AIDA model: Attention, Interest, Desire, and Action**. This means the homepage should guide every visitor step-by-step from the moment they arrive, right through to making an enquiry – rather than just displaying a catalogue of products.

Step 1 – The Hero Section (Top of the Page)

Use a large, high-quality full-width image or video at the top. Place a semi-transparent dark overlay over it so all text is easy to read. Show two prominent buttons side by side: one for visitors ready to enquire right now, and one for visitors who want to browse products first. This immediately serves the two main reasons someone visits the site.

Step 2 – The Credibility Bar

Directly below the hero section, show a horizontal bar with Varicon’s most important headline numbers – for example: “400+ Systems Installed”, “20+ Years of Experience”, “Clients in 30+ Countries”. These numbers should animate gently into view as the visitor scrolls down. This one simple bar does more to prove credibility than several paragraphs of text.

Step 3 – Industry Selection Cards

Show a grid of 3 or 4 cards that let visitors select their industry – for example: Aquaculture, Biotech, or Agriculture. Each card responds to mouse hover with a subtle zoom and shadow effect, showing it is clickable. Clicking takes the visitor to a page tailored to the specific needs of their industry.

Step 4 – Unified Product Section

Replace all the separate carousels with one clean section using tabs at the top: “Photobioreactors”, “Live Feed Equipment”, and “Consumables”. Visitors click a tab to switch between product categories in the same place on the page – no more scrolling through repeated sections, no more confusion.

Step 5 – Interactive Services Timeline

Replace the large text blocks in the Services section with a clear, clickable timeline. Each stage of Varicon’s service process – Feasibility Study, Plant Design, Scale-Up, Commercialization – is shown as a clearly labeled step. When a visitor clicks a step, the full detail expands below it. The page stays clean and easy to scan, while the full detail is always available.

Step 6 – Social Proof Section

Dedicate a visually distinct section to client testimonials and case study highlights. Label each one with the relevant industry (e.g., “Aquaculture”, “Biotech”) so visitors can quickly find proof that is directly relevant to their own situation. Relevant proof is far more convincing than generic proof.

Step 7 – The Enquiry Section (Bottom of the Page)

End the page with a high-impact block containing the “Get a Quote” contact form. Directly beside the form, show industry certifications, partner logos, and a clear statement of the expected response time. This combination builds confidence at the exact moment a visitor is deciding whether to submit their details.

Section 4: Mobile Strategy and Proposed Changes

Everything described in Section 3 must work correctly on mobile phones and tablets. The multi-column industry card grid should collapse into a vertical list or a swipe-able card carousel on small screens. The current three-level navigation menu must be completely replaced on mobile with a simple full-screen overlay menu that uses expandable accordion sections – so visitors can tap open only the sections they need.

Animations and motion effects should be used sparingly. Their purpose is to draw attention to important content at the right moment – not to distract or slow the page down. A scroll-triggered fade-in effect (content appears as you scroll down) creates a polished feel. The “Get a Quote” button should have a subtle colour change on hover to make it clear that clicking it leads somewhere useful.

Summary of Proposed Changes

Navigation Redesign

Reduce the top navigation to only the most essential categories. Place a clearly visible “Get a Quote” button – in Varicon’s teal brand colour – at the far right of the navigation bar, visible on every page. When a visitor hovers over a main navigation item, show a visual panel with

images and brief descriptions for each sub-category, so it is easy to scan and choose where to go next.

Homepage Section Order – AIDA Model

Reorder all homepage sections to follow the AIDA marketing model (Attention → Interest → Desire → Action). The correct order from top to bottom is:

Hero → Statistics Strip → Industry Cards → Testimonials → Products → Services → Case Studies → Final Call to Action

This sequence is designed to first grab attention, build interest and desire, and then prompt the visitor to take action by making an enquiry.

Hero Section Rewrite

Completely rewrite the hero section text to clearly and directly answer: “What does Varicon Aqua do?” and “Who is this for?” The call-to-action buttons should communicate outcomes, not just categories – for example: “Start Your Cultivation Project” or “Speak to a Specialist”. Add small clickable industry tags (e.g., [Aquaculture], [Biotech], [Agriculture]) in the hero section so visitors can instantly filter the experience to their own industry.

Build Trust Earlier on the Page

Place a statistics strip directly below the hero section: “400+ Systems Installed Worldwide” and “20+ Years of Industry Experience”. Move customer testimonials much higher up the homepage – not at the very bottom. Label each testimonial with the client’s industry so visitors can easily find testimony from someone in a situation similar to their own.

Products Section Simplification

Merge the two visually identical product carousels into a single tabbed interface. This removes the confusion, saves significant space on the page, and makes it much easier for visitors to browse Varicon’s entire product range without feeling lost or unsure about what they are looking at.

About Us Page

Add a proper job title and a one or two sentence biography for every team member. Add a visual company history timeline showing key milestones: when the company was founded, when major product lines were launched, and significant installation achievements. This gives potential clients a clear, compelling picture of Varicon’s depth of experience and long track record.